ecosystem a central plank of governance. From energy independence to farmer-centric power reforms, Fadnavis has consistently pushed Mahavitaran or Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Limited (MSEDCL) to shed legacy inefficiencies and think at scale. "You cannot build a trillion-dollar economy on unreliable power," he has said on multiple occasions, underscoring that electricity reform is not a sectoral initiative but an economic imperative. Under his watch, renewable-led reform moved from the margins to the core of Maharashtra's development agenda.

Execution, however, required an institutional transformer. That responsibility fell to Lokesh Chandra, the IAS officer who assumed charge of MSEDCL in June 2023, inheriting what many considered an unmanageable utility. With 3.4 crore consumers, ballooning debt, rising subsidy burdens, and peak demand expected to climb from 28 GW to 45 GW by 2030, Mahavitaran was at an inflection point. What followed has since drawn national and global attention.

In the sun-drenched fields of rural Maharashtra, farmers who once spent thousands on diesel now irrigate using solar-powered pumps at zero electricity cost. In Mumbai's industrial corridors, manufacturers are witnessing something unprecedented in Indian utility history—declining power tariffs. Globally, energy experts now reference the "Maharashtra model" as proof that emerging economies can leapfrog to clean energy without fiscal collapse. "The vision is simple but audacious," Chandra explains. "Maharashtra aims to be a $1 trillion economy. You cannot achieve that without reliable, affordable, and clean power. Our responsibility is to ensure uninterrupted electricity for farms, factories, and homes, while transitioning to 52% renewable energy by 2030."

Central to this effort is Mahavitaran's Resource Adequacy Plan, which mandates the addition of 45 GW of renewable capacity this decade, taking installed capacity from 36 GW to 81 GW. Through competitively bid solar and wind power purchase agreements, synchronized with battery storage, the utility has strengthened grid resilience while driving down costs. The result is projected procurement savings of ₹82,000 crore over five years—relieving industrial cross-subsidies and freeing fiscal space for rural investment.

Fadnavis has publicly credited this execution. "What we are witnessing under Shri Lokesh Chandra's leadership is the convergence of policy vision and administrative excellence," the Chief Minister noted at a December ceremony. "Schemes like MSKVY 2.0 and Magel Tyala Saur Krushi Pump Yojana required someone who could navigate complex procurement, manage stakeholder expectations, and deliver at scale. That is precisely what has happened."

The Mukhyamantri Saur Krushi Vahini Yojana (MSKVY) 2.0 stands as the centrepiece of this transformation. Designed as a 16 GW decentralised solar programme, it places modular photovoltaic parks within 5–10 kilometres of agriculture-dominated substations. By generating power close to consumption points, the scheme reduces transmission losses and avoids costly grid upgrades. Through a digital land-aggregation portal spanning 40,000 acres, over 3,000 MW has already been commissioned.

The impact is multi-dimensional. More than eight lakh farming households now receive assured daytime power. Annual procurement costs have fallen by ₹10,000 crore, while ₹65,000 crore in private investment has flowed in. The programme has generated over 70,000 green jobs and cuts 5.6 million tonnes of $CO_2$ emissions each year.

"For decades, agricultural power was our Achilles' heel," says Additional Chief Secretary Abha Shukla. "Subsidies were rising, losses were mounting, and farmers were still dissatisfied. MSKVY flipped the equation as farmers got better power, the state saved money, and private investment surged."

December 2025 marked a defining moment. In just 30 days, Mahavitaran installed 45,911 off-grid solar pumps under the Magel Tyala Saur Krushi Pump Yojana, earning a Guinness World Record. Total installations now stand at 7.47 lakh, irrigating over 22 lakh acres and eliminating diesel dependence.

"We installed 1.86 lakh pumps over several years until FY2023," Chandra notes. "In the last two years alone, we've installed 5.61 lakh. Maharashtra now accounts for 60% of all off-grid solar pumps in India." For Solapur farmer Ramdas Patil, the change is tangible. "My monthly electricity bill was ₹4,000, diesel cost another ₹6,000," he says. "Now it's zero. I irrigate when crops need water, not when power is available. My yield is up 20%."

Behind the success lies deep institutional reform. Chandra inherited ₹98,000 crore in debt, with ₹12,000 crore paid annually in interest. His strategy includes demerging the agricultural business—along with ₹75,000 crore in arrears—into a separate entity by 2026, enabling Mahavitaran to prepare for a stock market listing.

Simultaneously, business process reengineering is underway. AI-driven load forecasting, GIS-based asset tracking, remote substation monitoring, and smart metering are redefining operations. "We're not just a distribution company anymore," Chandra says. "We're becoming a technology platform that delivers electricity."

The model's credibility was reinforced at COP30 in Belém, Brazil, where international experts described MSKVY as directly replicable across Africa and Asia. Awards ranging from the UK World Record of Excellence to SKOCH Gold, have followed.

Yet Chandra remains measured. "Debt restructuring, digital deepening, and renewable integration at this scale will test us," he admits. What is indisputable is that with political resolve from the Prime Minister's office to the Chief Minister's chair, and administrative execution at Mahavitaran, Maharashtra has transformed power from constraint to catalyst. As India advances toward its economic ambitions, this convergence may well be remembered as the moment when clean energy became executable at scale, not aspirational, but inspirational and operational.



**Shri Lokesh Chandra, IAS,**
Chairman and Managing Director, MSEDCL

***"We're setting a template, Not just for India, but for any country that wants to grow without compromising the planet. That's the real legacy showing it can be done."***

